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Takeaways

- **Gaurav Gogoi made Assam PCC chief, will lead party in '26 poll**
- **Congress out of power in Assam for a decade, since 2016**
- **CM Himanta Sarma and BJP pursuing Gogoi with 'Pakistan connection' charge**

Lok Sabha election, and his visibility—and audibility—as the party's deputy leader in the Lok Sabha thereafter.

ELECTORAL MATH

The Congress is also seeking to solve Assam's complex electoral math in its usual way. Three new working presidents represent key demographics: Jakir Hussain Sikdar (Bengali-origin Muslim), Roselina Tirkey ('tea garden' tribal) and Pradip Sarkar (Bengali Hindu). Gaurav is from the Ahom community, historically crucial to electoral success in the state. With him positioned as de facto CM candidate, the party is also sending a powerful message—that they're backing him to the hilt despite Sarma lobbing allegations of a 'Pakistani connection' at Gaurav's British wife Elizabeth Colburn. Sarma's campaign over the past few months has included claims that Elizabeth worked for Pakistani agencies and that Gaurav visited the country on ISI invitation. Gaurav has called it a "C-grade Bollywood movie plot" and questioned Sarma's "mental state" while offering a nuanced refutation.

The 2024 Lok Sabha election marked a definitive turning point in Gaurav Gogoi's political career and his rivalry with Sarma. Delimitation had eliminated the old Gogoi pocketborough of Kaliabor, forcing him to contest from Jorhat, where his prospects appeared slim. Sarma arrayed the entire state apparatus against him, turning it into a prestige battle. So, when Gogoi won by 144,000-plus votes, it was more than just another LS seat win for the Congress—it shattered Sarma's aura of electoral invincibility.

Within the state unit, there's a mix of enthusiasm and pragmatic acceptance, with veterans aware that Gogoi is their best bet at the top. But his feet aren't planted too solidly: the Congress had a scare show in the recent panchayat polls, not winning a single zilla parishad seat in Jorhat, Gogoi's stronghold.

It's on this perilous turf that Gogoi stages his 2026 challenge. It's a clash of personalities. Also, a choice between two visions: Sarma's muscular, growth-focused approach vs Gogoi's social justice alternative. ■

▶ BIHAR

PK BIDS TO BE A THIRD FORCE

Prashant Kishor reshapes core team, blending caste calculus with credibility to position Jan Suraaj for the big poll fight

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

IT'S A PRASHANT KISHOR encore, so none of the mainstream parties had exactly wished for it. The October 2024 birth of Jan Suraaj Party was preceded by a good bit of labour: two full years, about 5,000 km, of pacing up and down the natal ward of Bihar. That hard-earned paternity is now entering its logical phase: the JSP aims to make it good in the coming state election. Prashant ('PK') has hit the ground running—with a rerun. He plans to criss-cross all 243 assembly constituencies before October-November with his *'Bihar badlaw yatra'*.

Bad law is just about right, as a spot of start-

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WALK THE TALK PK at the Patna leg of his yatra, May 23